

Chapter 146 - Mandarin Ducks

Finally, Ning Fuyi smiled awkwardly and turned around with her hands behind her back, just like Liu Wenzhu. She casually conjured a set of clothes and threw them to Hua Feihua's front while facing away.

"It's cold outside. Young Sect Master should wear more," Ning Fuyi said.

Hua Feihua, who had consecutively been caught in her secret by two people, was speechless for a moment. She reached out to take the clothes and put them on, finally making an effort to speak again: "Today's events - please, you two must not let a fourth person know."

After speaking, she quickly changed clothes. Once the leather belt was fastened, she was again a refined young man.

She had just finished dressing when sounds came from outside the door. Ning Fuyi was quick-witted and sent out a flying light that sealed the bronze door like a spider web. They could hear chaotic noise outside, with people forcefully ramming the door, causing the surrounding walls to shake.

"They've come as expected," Ning Fuyi said. "I just severely rebuked Hua Hong and originally intended to spar with him a few more rounds, using pressure and enticement to make him hand over the puppets. But I inadvertently heard a servant report that the Four Direction Stone had suddenly shattered."

"I guessed it was related to you two. Seeing Hua Hong dispatch people to capture you, I lied about our conversation going poorly and took my leave, slipping back to help you."

Flying Flower Sect's strength was outstanding. With just Hua Feihua and Liu Wenzhu, they might not necessarily escape. She could only abandon those puppets for now - saving people was more important.

And after glimpsing the injuries on Hua Feihua, it proved her choice was correct. That Hua Hong was truly a hypocritical creature, capable of being so ruthless even to his own flesh and blood.

"The pursuers are getting more numerous," Liu Wenzhu slowly retreated, saying uneasily.

"Since I invited you two to come, I won't implicate you," Hua Feihua gritted her teeth and stood up. Though her lips were pale from pain, she didn't cry out. "There's still a secret passage here. Follow me."

She turned and used her bloodied hand to paint several strokes on the wall, somehow triggering a mechanism. The bronze wall and iron barrier instantly turned to molten iron, melting and flowing, creating a door opening tall enough for a person.

"This secret passage leads directly to the outside world - it's most convenient for escape." Hua Feihua pushed Liu Wenzhu into the opening, then turned back to pull Ning Fuyi, but Ning Fuyi stopped her and indicated she should go first.

Hua Feihua glanced at Ning Fuyi, lowered her brows, and crawled into the opening, disappearing into the darkness.

At the same time, there was a tremendous crash as the bronze door behind them was smashed open by bronze and iron arms. Smoke immediately filled the secret chamber. Ning Fuyi's expression remained unchanged as she silently recited incantations, causing pink lightning to shoot out like fireworks, bouncing off the bronze walls and iron barriers to form a dense electric net.

Ning Fuyi heard the piercing screams of terror from the other side of the door and knew the pursuers were temporarily blocked. Only then did she turn and drop into the doorway, quickening her pace to catch up with the other two.

Hua Feihua was obviously exhausted and walked very slowly. Liu Wenzhu supported her with one hand while anxiously looking back with the other. When she saw Ning Fuyi's figure, she finally breathed a sigh of relief.

"Hiss..." Hua Feihua painfully contracted her arms, her clear eyes narrowing to slits as she looked at Liu Wenzhu.

"Sorry," Liu Wenzhu quickly let go.

"Young Sect Master, please bear with it. Wenzhu is just like this - usually fine, but when anxious she easily loses control of her strength. It's best to keep some distance from her at such times," Ning Fuyi said.

"Yiyi!" Liu Wenzhu said indignantly, while Ning Fuyi spread her hands toward her, showing a triumphant smile.

Hua Feihua initially maintained her composure, but upon hearing the two bicker, she finally showed a subtle smile.

There were no obstructions in the secret passage, so they quickly reached the end. Ning Fuyi was cautious and didn't directly lead them flying out. Instead, before leaving the opening, she first threw a stone outside.

The stone didn't fall in an arc as it should have, but stopped when it was about to fly into the daylight, then crumbled to powder in the blink of an eye.

"There really is an ambush!" Liu Wenzhu said angrily, then conjured her thousand-pound hammer. The hammer, mixed with flames, embedded into the formation, vibrated for a moment, and the formation shattered like glass into pieces.

As the formation broke, a giant hand reached in from outside the opening, smashing many rocks along the way and striking directly at Liu Wenzhu.

Ning Fuyi flashed forward the moment the hand reached in, joining Liu Wenzhu to face the iron palm - one using brute force, the other relying on immortal power to push the puppet out of the opening.

But Flying Flower Sect's puppets were, after all, top-level mechanism arts. Though repelled, they couldn't be destroyed. Fortunately, Hua Feihua urgently called out from behind: "Attack three cun¹ below its elbow - there's a depression there!"

Ning Fuyi's body immediately became as flexible as wind. Her waist twisted as she slid past the puppet's arm, her fingertips quickly finding the spot and jabbing forcefully into it.

There came a series of clicking sounds, and the puppet swayed in place twice before going rigid and motionless.

But just as the puppet was destroyed, several thick vines suddenly broke free from the earth, rising into the air like iron chains and completely pulverizing the overhead rocks, revealing the bright blue sky.

The "iron chains" then stabbed down from mid-air, reaching Ning Fuyi's head in the blink of an eye. Ning Fuyi quickly turned her head to dodge the vines, creating a pit a person's height and width beneath her feet.

"Wasn't Sect Master Hua Hong feeling unwell? How is he so vigorous now!" Ning Fuyi spoke mockingly, then reached out to summon her Emei needles, holding them defensively in front of her.

"I, Hua Hong, treated you with courtesy, yet never imagined you would abduct my eldest son!" Hua Hong said with furrowed brows. "You spoke eloquently about coming for the immortal sects, but I see it was all trickery!"

Naturally, Ning Fuyi wouldn't back down, sneering: "I still considered you a righteous person, but never imagined you would privately abuse your own child. Even a tiger doesn't eat its cubs - how venomous must Sect Master Hua be to injure Hua Feihua so severely!"

"Stop talking nonsense!" Hua Hong scolded, his gaze scornfully sweeping over Ning Fuyi. "Hua Feihua is my son - can't I discipline him? You forcefully interfere in another sect's family affairs. Is this how Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate taught you, you scoundrel!"

"Father!" Hua Feihua frowned and stepped forward. "It was I who asked them for help. You..."

But before she could finish speaking, a vine suddenly flew down from the air, transforming into a whip full of fierce wind that immediately struck Hua Feihua to the ground.

This blow hit her squarely in the chest. Hua Feihua rolled among the rocks and couldn't raise her head for a long time.

"Sect Master Hua! What are you doing!" How could Liu Wenzhu bear to watch this? She quickly jumped into the scattered rocks to pull the person up, turning back to say: "She is your flesh and blood, not a puppet for you to punish at will!"

"My Hua family's affairs are none of your business, you young girl!" Hua Hong said, then pointed at Hua Feihua. "You rebellious child, how long will you continue to defy me before you repent!"

"I used to cherish you for being gentle, refined, and intelligent, showing you great care. But now you're becoming increasingly outrageous - even your younger brother surpasses you!"

Under Hua Hong's angry scolding, Hua Feihua endured the pain and looked up. Tears glistened in those calm eyes, but ultimately didn't fall.

"Father speaks of being outrageous - what kind of outrageous behavior is it?"

"Is it not colluding with you to casually brand people as demons? Or is it unwilling to let you be timid and cowardly, coveting comfort while abandoning the common people and the world?"

"Or is it that whenever I go against your wishes even slightly, you put on the airs of a father and punish me in every way?"

"Hua Feihua." Hua Hong's face had turned iron-blue from rage, his eye sockets sunken as he stared intensely at the speaking "young man," issuing a warning.

"I used to respect and love you, obeying you in everything, but not anymore," Hua Feihua said clearly, each word distinct. "I risked danger to ask them to rescue me precisely to tell you - I want to follow the path in my heart."

"There were originally no immortals in the world. People became immortals through self-improvement. Cultivators cultivate for people, for themselves, for the masses, for all living beings. I'm unwilling to be cowardly and afraid of death, to go along with wrongdoing!"

As soon as she finished speaking, another vine broke through the air toward her back. But this time Ning Fuyi was prepared - her Emei needles flew from her hands, severing the vine at its roots.

The falling section was caught by Liu Wenzhu, who crushed it into wood pulp with her bare hands and threw it into the soil.

"Poisonous old fox," even the usually gentle Liu Wenzhu was angry, cursing quietly but politely.

Hua Hong looked as if he had truly been angered into illness. His eyes seemed ready to burst from their sockets, wanting to scold but finding himself speechless, wanting to take action, but the two women before him were not easy opponents.

Liu Wenzhu was just a young girl, but he had experienced Ning Fuyi's formidable abilities at Flying Flower Tower before. Now with just him alone, he definitely couldn't defeat them.

Thinking it over this way, Hua Hong could only give up. He pointed his trembling finger at Hua Feihua, and after a long while, squeezed out an age-old cliché.

"From now on, consider that I never raised you, you rebellious child!"

After saying this, he turned around in rage and disappeared beneath the green mountains.

Only then did Hua Feihua close her eyes that had been open all along. As if instantly drained of strength, she softly knelt and sat, staring at the ground in a daze.

Ning Fuyi also put away her Emei needles, cast a contemptuous glance in the direction Hua Hong had departed, walked to Hua Feihua's side, and patted her shoulder in comfort.

"This matter is resolved. Don't be afraid. Even if Flying Flower Sect won't accept you, you can return to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate with us. At worst, there's still the Liu family - we definitely won't let you be homeless," Liu Wenzhu said righteously, then her dark brows fell.

"It's just that Elder Pingyao entrusted me with a task, and I've botched it," Liu Wenzhu sighed softly. "Without a puppet army to form formations, who knows how many more immortal sect disciples will die."

Ning Fuyi was about to speak when she saw Hua Feihua, who had been dejected on the ground, suddenly reach out and lightly bump Ning Fuyi's knee with her fist, then turn her wrist and open her palm.

In the center of her clean, white palm lay an ancient, simple bronze key.

"I am Flying Flower Sect's Young Sect Master. In the entire Flying Flower Sect, besides Father, I am the most proficient in puppet manipulation," Hua Feihua placed the key in Ning Fuyi's hand.

"Here - the puppet army," she said.

And so Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu somehow managed to borrow thousands of bronze puppets and somehow brought back a person.

After returning to Jingshan Palace, Ning Fuyi circled around Chu Qingqiu for an entire morning, telling her everything that had happened at Flying Flower Sect. But except for when she heard about Ning Fuyi's confrontation with Hua Hong, which made her look up, Chu Qingqiu wasn't surprised by anything else. She just kept her head down, stitching back and forth on a piece of white silk.

Ning Fuyi really couldn't get her attention, so she rested her chin on her shoulder and said: "I also learned a secret this time, but I promised to keep it secret, so I can't tell you."

Chu Qingqiu's eyelashes lifted slightly, almost rolling her eyes, but her good upbringing restrained her, and she just said "oh."

"Truly a Divine Venerable - completely unmoved by other people's secrets," Ning Fuyi pretended to sigh.

"Other people's secrets have nothing to do with me. Why should I care?" Chu Qingqiu said.

"I only care about yours," she added.

Ning Fuyi's heart had just sunk because of the first sentence, but upon hearing the second, it immediately leaped up, almost jumping out of her throat.

She wrapped her arms around her waist from behind, resting her chin on her left shoulder, looking over her shoulder at what was in her hands.

Chu Qingqiu was holding an embroidery hoop, and the needle and thread had already taken shape, though the form was rather bold. Even with Ning Fuyi examining it from left and right, she couldn't make out what it was supposed to be.

She didn't even know when Chu Qingqiu had developed such a hobby, using those delicate hands that had never touched mundane water to do embroidery.

But what was even more troubling was that Chu Qingqiu actually asked her how well she thought the embroidery was done.

Between lovers, praise is most needed, so Ning Fuyi said decisively that it was good, her phoenix eyes curved: "Strong foundation, fine silk, lifelike."

Chu Qingqiu seemed to believe her, her voice becoming lighter: "Then can you tell what I've embroidered?"

Ning Fuyi's heart immediately lost its confidence. She squinted and examined it for a while longer, then smiled confidently: "Thick legs, round head - it must be 'two rabbits running side by side'²."

The Chu Qingqiu in her arms was silent for a long while before finally putting down her needle and thread and speaking quietly.

"It's mandarin ducks playing in a spring pond."

Author's Note:

Yiyi: I was careless... Which family's mandarin ducks have four legs?

Footnotes:

1. **Cun (寸)** - A traditional Chinese unit of length, approximately equivalent to one thumb-width or about 3.33 centimeters
2. **"Two rabbits running side by side" (双兔傍地走)** - A reference to a line from the famous Chinese poem "The Ballad of Mulan," where it describes how it's difficult to tell male and female rabbits apart when they're running together, used metaphorically about gender ambiguity